

GET A Grip

A secret agent needs to be on his toes always and what better way to keep the mind and reflexes razor sharp than a spot of gaming and matching wits and skills against worthy adversaries?

And I have the best of all the necessary paraphernalia that an ace gamer should have—a GeForce3 graphics card, all the RAM I could ask for and a machine tweaked to perfection. But something's missing. For a truly immersive gaming experience what I need is something that will let me feel the bump and grind of the game. Hence I asked to be put on 'Mission: Gaming Peripherals'.

Early on in the mission I realised that there isn't a one-size-fits-all, versatile peripheral in the market. If it's versatility you are looking for, nothing really beats the old keyboard and mouse combination. Most PC games are not originally designed with gaming controllers in mind; they work better with the mice and keyboard arrangement. This is especially true with first person shooter (FPS) and strategy games, although you do get tailor-made mice like the Razer Boomslang and the Strategic Commander, one NRI uncle away.

An excursion to the Mecca of hardware, Lamington Road, and this is what I found: the gaming hardware was of two broad categories—cheap and functional, and feature laden and expensive. If money is no issue for you, there are peripherals that cost more than the PlayStation. Logitech and Microsoft have gamepads, steering wheels, and joysticks that are rugged, easy to use, feature rich, with reprogrammable buttons and force feedback. The Microsoft SideWinder Precision Pro Joystick had a price tag of Rs 5,000. The Logitech Wingman Extreme Digital 3D (nothing 'extreme', 'digital', or '3D' about it) had an asking price of Rs 2,600. These are the most expensive non force feedback joysticks I came across. The force feedback upgrade came at an average of Rs 3,000 more. Games are a lot more gripping with force feedback—you can feel the



ILLUSTRATION: Mahesh Benkar

Hard Disks



If you've been looking to upgrade to a higher-capacity hard drive, now's the time to pull out your wallet and spend some money. Hard drives are crashing to prices as low as Rs 4,650 for a 40 GB capacity and prices are expected to fall further.

bumps on the road while driving on a force feedback wheel, or the rumble of your aircraft when it gets hit. Great for enhancement freaks, but of course all this comes at a price

There's a glut of lesser-known imports at Heera Panna, an imported goods shop in Mumbai, and you get pretty much what you paid for. The price range for joysticks started from Rs 500. The expensive ones had more buttons and thicker plastic. Frontech had a good selection of joysticks in the price range of Rs 550 to Rs 1,300. The cheaper makes of joysticks from A4-Tech, Frontech and Dexxa will get the job done but the workmanship and precision on the joysticks and steering wheels is not as durable as those from Logitech and Microsoft.

If I were to buy something cheap, I'd go for a gamepad as they can stand a lot of abuse and can work for a wide variety of games. The E-Z gamepad from A-4 Tech was just for Rs 350, a must buy if you're tired of playing console games on the keyboard.

There are a lot of other extras you could go for, like Virtual Reality (VR) glasses. These aren't available as a separate add on, only select ASUS cards have this feature. The 3D VR glasses can make all your Direct 3D games jump out from the screen and the newest beta drivers will also work with OpenGL. It takes some getting used to at first but the effects can be really amazing. It would be wise to invest in a headphone and microphone set, now that voice in multiplayer games are becoming a widely accepted standard.

You can never have too much of a good thing can you? Now that my report is ready, my next mission is to convince the Big Boss to finance my new arsenal of gaming peripherals. ■

What to Buy

Game	Best suited peripheral	Price Range	Caveat
Flight Simulator, Space Sim	Joystick	Rs 500-8,000	An unexciting range of games and lack of versatility means that only flight sim enthusiasts will opt for this
Sports, Arcade, Fighting, Console Ports	Gamepad	Rs 350-4,500	The high-end gamepads aren't all that they're cracked up to be
Racing	Force feedback wheel	Rs 2500-10,000	A steering wheel without force feedback is an utter waste of your time
FPS, Strategy	Keyboard and mouse	D-uh, you already have it	Buy a wireless mouse and keyboard combo, or an optical mouse

